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Integrating Gender Considerations into Green Finance for Rural Revitalization: Opportunities for UNDP China

将性别考量融入绿色金融与乡村振兴：UNDP 中国机遇

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Capstone Faculty Advisor: Prof. Katherine Morton

Date of Defense: June 5th, 2026



Presentation Outline

1. Research Motivation
2. Topic & Research Question
3. Literature Review
4. Research Methodology
5. Analysis & Main Findings
6. Recommendations
7. Conclusion

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Research Motivation

“Why does gender remains so consistently absent from climate finance design, and what can be done to change that”

70%

of the rural labour force in China are women. The agricultural sector is the most exposed to climate change

0.01%

of global climate finance supports projects that advance both climate action and women's empowerment
(Q. Xu, 2025)



Gender is almost entirely absent from national climate policy language and the design of climate finance instruments
(Zhou & Sun, 2020; Jeffs, 2023)

Gender inclusive efforts tend to produce better outcomes for everyone: higher loan repayment rates among women borrowers and a positive relationship between board gender diversity and green bond issuance in Chinese firms
(Wen et al., 2025, p. 1).

Research Motivation

Why the UNDP?



Research Motivation

Why the UNDP?

Why China?

- China leads the global green transition (#1 carbon market and green bond market).
- The choices being made now will shape the structure of China's climate finance architecture for years to come.

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Topic & Research Questions

MAIN QUESTION :

“How can the UNDP support Chinese stakeholders in integrating gender considerations into green finance planning and implementation for rural revitalization?”

SUB QUESTIONS :

1. **Frameworks:** What institutional tools does UNDP China currently use to integrate gender into climate finance programming?
2. **Implementation challenges and gaps:** What practical challenges emerge when these frameworks meet the Chinese context?
3. **Pathways forward:** What concrete recommendations can be drawn from the literature and our findings?

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Literature Review



International Frameworks for Gender Responsive Programming

Relationship between gender and climate finance in China

Rural Revitalization, Digital Development, and Women's Participation

International Frameworks for Gender Responsive Programming

- Principles: gender applies everywhere + address structural causes of gender based inequality
- UNDP Gender Seal: Bronze, Silver, and Gold Levels



China’s Policy Context: Mature Systems, Weak Linkage



Green finance system

Institutionalized, technocratic, and risk-management oriented

Green credit · green bonds · insurance · carbon finance

CORE GAP

Gender is recognized, but not operationalized



Women’s development & gender equality architecture

Institutionalized, state-led, and development-oriented

Legal protection · women’s participation · family policy

UNDP opportunity: institutional translation: Translate gender mainstreaming into China-legible policy language, evaluation practice, and financing logics

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Rural Revitalization, Digital Development, and Women's Participation



- Left-behind rural women manage agriculture and rural stability but are excluded from governance decisions
- Three barriers limit rural women's governance participation:
  - structural
  - material
  - capability

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Research Approach

A mixed-methods study *examining how gender considerations are integrated, limited, or overlooked in China's green finance practice through four complementary data sources.*

The study triangulates interviews and field observation with policy, document, and case analysis to connect gender, green finance, and rural development in practice.

Data & Stakeholders, Methodology Strengths

UN PRACTITIONERS

Semi-structured interviews

UNDP China
UN Women USA
UNDP India

6 interviews ·
8 respondents

FIELD OBSERVATION

Non-participant Observation

UNDP-CICETE Rural Revitalization conference

Chengbu, Hunan (Jan 2026)

PRIVATE SECTOR

Written exchange with WeBank Green Finance Team

Parallel reference point for Chinese digital finance and MSME lending

SECONDARY SOURCES

Policy documents
UNDP project materials
Corporate / ESG reports
Public reporting
Illustrative cases

Adaptive design	Access maximization	Evidence triangulation	Policy relevance
Responds to real-world access constraints	Uses available interviews, fieldwork, documents, and cases	Cross-checks findings across multiple sources	Generates practical insights for UNDP and Chinese stakeholders

Illustrative Case Analysis



- **Primary case: UNDP–Du Xiaoman Partnership**: Sustainable finance partnership for rural MSMEs
- **Local sub-case: Rushan oyster farming**: Links local industry, ecology, finance, and women's participation
- **Purpose**: Connect policy discourse with local implementation
- **Scope and limitation:** Cases provide analytical depth rather than statistical generalizability

Image source: UNDP China

Evaluation Framework

Deductive coding

Predefined categories from the research question and gender-mainstreaming frameworks

Captured:

- UNDP gender tools
- Project and policy frameworks
- Financial access
- Beneficiary participation
- Rural enterprise needs
- Implementation barriers

TRIANGULATION

Cross-source validation of key findings

Inductive coding

Recurring patterns emerging from interviews, written exchange, observation, and documents

Identified:

- Financing barriers
- Care responsibilities
- Women's leadership roles
- Government gender-equality measures
- Gender implications in local practice

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Interview Findings

- UNDP China complies with gender markers but **hasn't culturally internalized gender thinking** at the project level
- **Gender data stops at headcount:** lack of measurement of economic outcomes, care burden, or household voice
- Gender gets designed out: when a project is "about" solar PV, **gender questions become secondary**



Interview Findings



- Government partners treat gender as a box to check
- UN gender vocabulary is illegible to investors
- The Du Xiaoman project is a strong model
- Private sector recognizes gender as relevant but has no tools, definitions, or regulatory incentives to act

Chengbu County Field Trip Analysis

Honeybee Enterprise | Embroidery Factory | Conference





- Women were represented in indoor, processing-oriented work, while upstream beekeeping appeared more male-dominated.

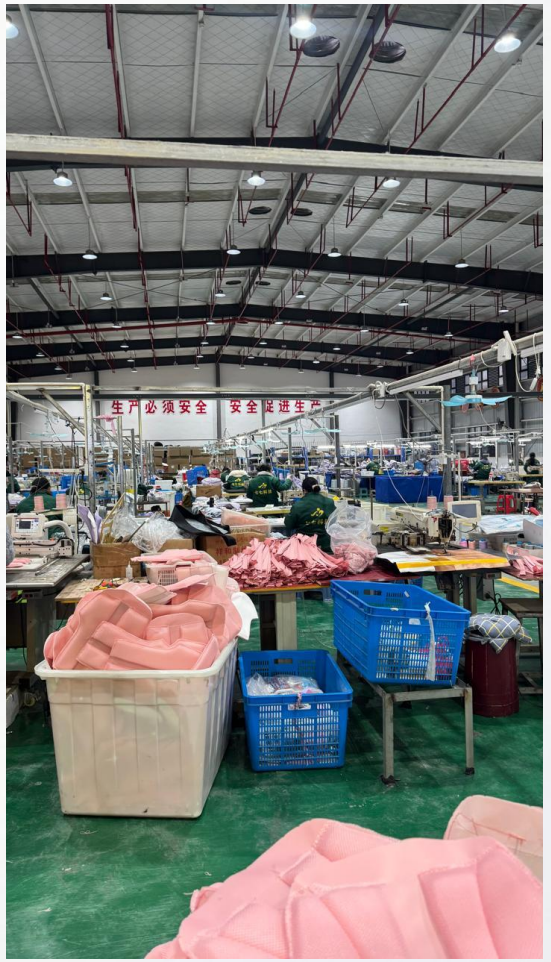
While **women's numerical majority inside the factory is an advancement, it does not necessarily translate into parity in economic position** or decision-making within the sector.

Chengbu County Field Trip Analysis

Honeybee Enterprise | **Embroidery Factory** | Conference

- **Yang Shuting**: disabled entrepreneur, leads an enterprise employing 68 disabled workers
- National March 8th Red Flag Holder

What conditions can make more women reach this position **without relying on exceptional individuals and stories**?





Chengbu County Field Trip Analysis

Honeybee Enterprise | **Embroidery Factory** | **Conference**





- Women as contributors, not just beneficiaries: a step toward gender-transformative thinking
- But the analysis stayed quantitative: headcounts and training numbers
- What participation meant in women's lives went uncaptured

What isn't measured can't be funded

Policy & Private-Sector Findings

- **Policy analysis:**

  Policy-language mismatch and insufficient contextualization create an implementation gap.

- **WeBank finding:**

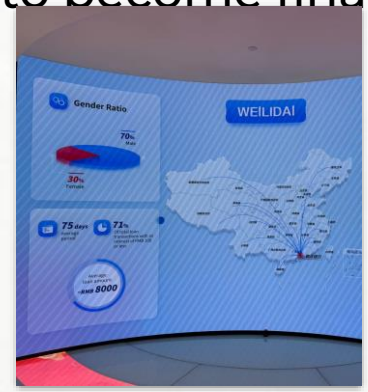
  Inclusive finance does not automatically become gender-responsive finance.

  - Four barriers: Data gaps, unclear definitions, product complexity, and limited incentives.

- **Core gap is in operational translation:**

  Gender goals need to become financial tools, criteria, and metrics.





Inclusion needs tools, not only commitments

Du Xiaoman & Rushan Oyster Farming Case Findings

- **UNDP–Du Xiaoman Partnership:**

  Links rural revitalization, sustainable finance, and women's development.

- **Rushan case:**

  Connects oyster farming, ecological value, carbon finance, and women entrepreneurs.

- **Key strength:**

  Gender is made visible through local industry pathways.

- **Remaining gap:**

  Visibility and participation has not yet become embedded financial design.





Image source: XHBY.net / Bandao.cn

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Recommendations: Internal

Building the evidence base and the capacity behind it

1. **Strengthen measurement (M&E)**

- Track outcomes (economic position, care burden, voice) not just attendance
- Commission 12–24 month follow-up studies to build longitudinal evidence
- Document projects in two formats: written briefs and video narratives

2. **Improve training quality and targeting**

- Design training around women's care schedules
- Build digital competency: payments, e-commerce, portals
- Extend training into leadership
- Differentiate by age: leadership content for older women, entrepreneurship for younger

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Recommendations: Partner-Facing

Making gender legible and self-sustaining with partners

1. **Localize the policy framing**
- Lead with Chinese policy frames (乡村振兴, 妇女发展), not UN mainstreaming language
- Shift gender from reporting to project design

2. Strengthen women's roles in implementation
- Push for more women in implementation roles (project managers)
- Build mentorship tracks: internal (career) and alumni (rural women / MSME owners post-project)

3. Develop operational tools
- Create a bilingual operational guide: what counts as a "women-led" green enterprise, what gender-responsive design looks like

4. Engage finance in its own language
- Speak finance's terms to banks: risk mitigation, client segmentation, ESG — using Du Xiaoman as the pilot case

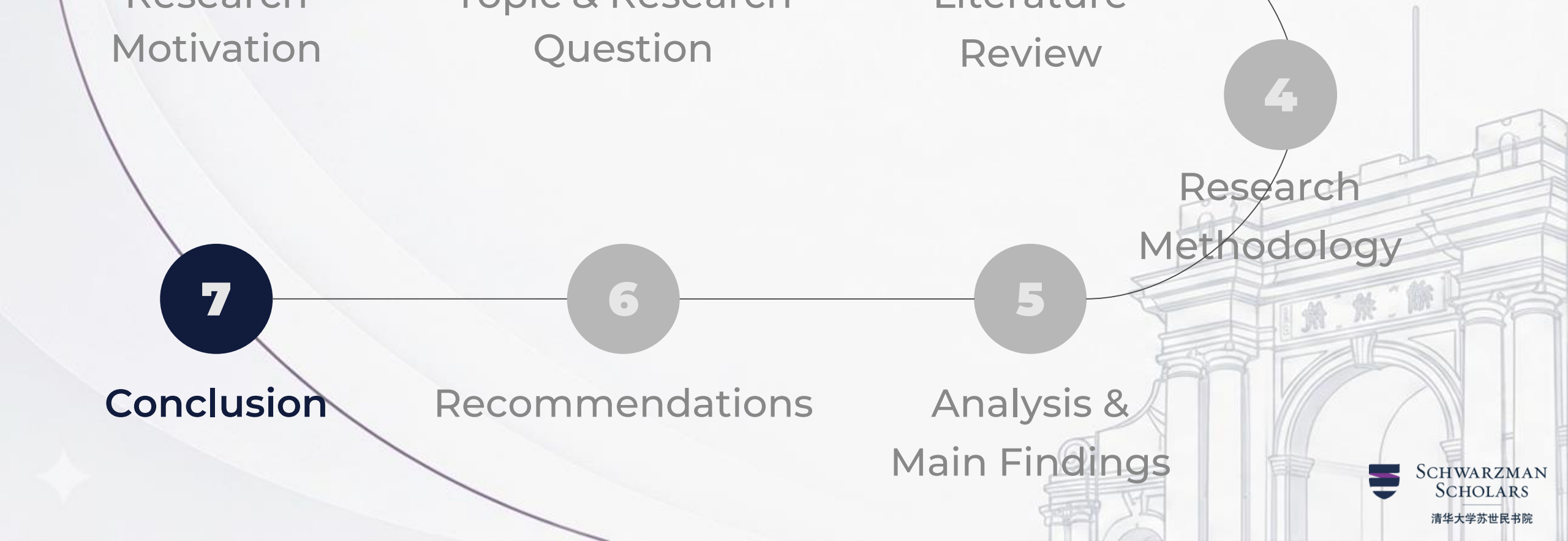
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Conclusions

Gender integration advances when it's made legible, local, and evidence-based

1

In climate finance
Gender neutral
=
Gender blind

2

男女平等
≠
Gender mainstreaming

3

Formal parity gives the **illusion of equality achieved**

Across the recommendations, **UNDP's role is to work within Chinese policy grammar** and **build the evidence** base that makes **gender legible to partners and bankable to finance.**

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Thank you

and we welcome your questions!



